

Absolutely — **smell** is a strong polysemy target because your passage uses it here:

> “...what caught my attention first was not the signboard, but the **smell**.”

Here **smell** means **an odour/aroma detected by the nose**, specifically the pleasant smell of freshly baked bread. But the word also works as a verb meaning **to detect an odour**, **to give off an odour**, and figuratively **to sense that something is wrong or suspicious**.

Word family: **smell / smelled / smelt / smelling / smelly**

Base word: smell

Verb forms: smell, smells, smelled/smelt, smelling

Related adjective: smelly

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Regional note:

> **smelled** = standard everywhere

> **smelt** = also common in BrE as past tense/past participle

Meaning in your passage: **smell = odour/aroma detected by the nose — 氣味 ; 香味**

Your sentence:

> “...what caught my attention first was not the signboard, but the **smell**.”

Here **smell** means:

> **a particular odour that can be detected through the nose.**

繁體中文 :

鼻子可以感受到的某種氣味 ; 此處特別指新鮮麵包散發出的香味

Natural translation:

> “What caught my attention first was not the signboard, but the smell.”

「最先吸引我注意的不是招牌，而是那股**香味 / 氣味**。」

So here:

> **smell = 氣味 ; 在此語境是令人愉快的香味**

1. **smell = odour / scent — 氣味；味道；香味**

The core noun meaning.

Practice 1 — Original

> “What caught my attention first was the **smell**.”

「最先吸引我注意的是那股**香味**。」

Practice 2

> “There was a lovely **smell** of bread in the shop.”

「店裡有一股很好聞的麵包**香味**。」

Practice 3

> “I noticed a strange smell in the room.”

「我注意到房間裡有一股奇怪的**氣味**。」

smell = 鼻子可以察覺到的某種氣味

Important:

smell itself is neutral. It can be pleasant or unpleasant.

2. **a bad smell = 臭味；難聞的氣味**

A common contextual use.

Practice 4

> “There was a bad **smell** coming from the bin.”

「垃圾桶傳來一股難聞的**臭味**。」

Practice 5

> “The fridge had an unpleasant smell.”

「雪櫃裡有一股難聞的**氣味**。」

****smell = 可指難聞氣味，但單字本身並不等於「臭味」****

This learner point is important.

3. ****sense of smell = 嗅覺****

A major physiological meaning.

Practice 6

> “Dogs have a very strong ****sense of smell****.”

「狗有非常敏銳的****嗅覺****。」

Practice 7

> “A cold can temporarily affect your sense of smell.”

「感冒可能暫時影響你的****嗅覺****。」

****sense of smell = 用鼻子辨認氣味的感官能力****

4. ****smell + noun/object = 聞到；嗅到****

Now ****smell**** is a verb meaning detect an odour.

Practice 8

> “I could ****smell**** fresh bread from outside.”

「我在外面就能****聞到****新鮮麵包的香味。」

Practice 9

> “Can you smell smoke?”

「你有沒有****聞到****煙味？」

****smell = 透過嗅覺察覺某種氣味****

5. **smell + adjective = 聞起來.....**

A major linking-verb pattern.

Practice 10

> “The bread **smells amazing**.”

「這麵包**聞起來很香 / 很棒**。」

Practice 11

> “The milk smells strange.”

「這牛奶**聞起來怪怪的**。」

smell + adjective = 某物散發出的氣味給人某種感覺

Common:

* smell good

* smell bad

* smell fresh

* smell strange

* smell delicious

6. **smell of + noun = 有.....的氣味；聞起來像.....**

Practice 12

> “The room **smelled of coffee**.”

「房間裡有一股**咖啡味**。」

Practice 13

> “His clothes smelled of smoke.”

「他的衣服有一股**煙味**。」

smell of X = 散發出 X 的氣味

7. **smell like + noun = 聞起來像.....**

Practice 14

> “This candle **smells like vanilla**.”

「這支蠟燭**聞起來像雲呢拿**。」

Practice 15

> “The kitchen smelled like fresh bread.”

「廚房**聞起來像剛出爐的麵包一樣香**。」

smell like X = 氣味與 X 相似

8. **smell = deliberately sniff something — 聞一聞；嗅一嗅**

A deliberate-action use.

Practice 16

> “She **smelled** the flowers.”

「她**聞了聞**那些花。」

Practice 17

> “He smelled the milk before drinking it.”

「他喝牛奶前先**聞了一下**。」

smell something = 主動把某物靠近鼻子去辨認氣味

This differs from accidentally detecting a smell.

9. **smell = give off an unpleasant odour — 發臭；有臭味**

A common intransitive use.

Practice 18

> “The rubbish is starting to **smell**.”

「垃圾開始**發臭**了。」

Practice 19

> “These shoes smell.”

「這雙鞋**有臭味**。」

****smell — intransitive = 本身散發出明顯氣味，尤其常暗示難聞****

Here, unlike neutral noun ****smell****, the bare verb:

> “It smells.”

often carries a negative implication.

10. ****smell bad / smell awful = 聞起來很臭；難聞****

Practice 20

> “The drain ****smells awful****.”

「去水渠**聞起來很臭**。」

Practice 21

> “Something in the fridge smells bad.”

「雪櫃裡有東西**發出難聞氣味**。」

****smell bad/awful = 散發令人不舒服的氣味****

11. ****smell = detect/sense something figuratively — 察覺；嗅出****

A major figurative sense.

Practice 22

> “I can ****smell trouble****.”

「我可以**嗅出要出事了 / 感覺到麻煩**。」

Practice 23

> “She could smell danger before anyone else reacted.”

「在其他人有反應之前，她已經**察覺到危險**。」

****smell — figurative = 靠直覺察覺某種危險、麻煩或異常****

This extends physical smelling into intuition.

12. ****smell a rat = 覺得有可疑之處；懷疑有問題****

A very common idiom worth flagging.

Practice 24

> “When the story changed again, I ****smelled a rat****.”

「故事又改口時，我就**覺得事情有可疑**。」

Practice 25

> “She smelled a rat when the figures did not match.”

「數字對不上時，她就**懷疑有問題**。」

****smell a rat = 覺得事情不對勁，懷疑有人欺騙或隱瞞****

This is idiomatic.

13. ****smell of + abstract noun = 帶有……意味；令人聯想到……****

A figurative literary/formal extension.

Practice 26

> “The whole deal ****smells of corruption****.”

「整件交易**帶有貪腐的味道 / 令人懷疑涉及貪腐**。」

Practice 27

> “His explanation smelled of desperation.”

「他的解釋**帶著一種絕望的意味**。」

smell of X — figurative = 某事令人感覺帶有某種負面性質 / 嫌疑

Often negative.

14. **smelly = 有臭味的；難聞的**

A major related adjective.

Practice 28

> “The bin is **smelly**.”

「垃圾桶很**臭**。」

Practice 29

> “Take those smelly shoes outside.”

「把那雙**有臭味的鞋**拿出去。」

smelly = 散發明顯難聞氣味的

Important:

smelly is strongly negative.

Important distinction: **smell vs aroma**

Directly relevant to your passage because the next sentence uses **aroma**.

smell

neutral/general:

can be pleasant or unpleasant.

aroma

usually pleasant, especially food/drink.

> smell of bread

> = 麵包氣味

> aroma of freshly baked bread

> = 新鮮出爐麵包的香氣

So in your passage:

****aroma**** is more positive and appetizing than plain ****smell****.

Important distinction: ****smell vs scent****

****smell****

broad neutral term.

****scent****

often pleasant or distinctive, especially:

* flowers

* perfume

* animals tracking smell

> floral scent

> = 花香

> bad smell

> = 臭味

****Scent**** is usually more refined/pleasant in human contexts.

Important distinction: ****smell vs fragrance****

****fragrance****

usually pleasant, refined aroma.

****smell****

can be pleasant, neutral, or unpleasant.

> fragrance of perfume

> = 香水香氣

> strange smell

> = 奇怪氣味

Important distinction: **smell vs stink**

smell

neutral.

stink

strongly negative:

= 發臭 / 惡臭

> “The room smells.”

may imply bad smell, but mildly.

> “The room stinks.”

= 房間臭死了。

Much stronger.

Important distinction: **smell vs taste**

smell

detected by the nose.

taste

detected mainly in the mouth/tongue.

> “The coffee smells good.”

= 咖啡聞起來很香。

> “The coffee tastes good.”

= 咖啡喝起來很好喝。

Very important learner distinction.

Important distinction: ****smell vs sniff****

****smell****

= detect or deliberately examine an odour.

****sniff****

= breathe in through the nose, often audibly/briefly, to smell something.

> “She smelled the flowers.”

= 她聞花香。

> “She sniffed the flowers.”

= 她湊近吸了一下鼻子聞花。

****Sniff**** emphasizes the physical action.

Important distinction: ****smell something vs smell of something****

****smell something****

= detect its odour

> “I smell coffee.”

= 我聞到咖啡味。

****smell of something****

= emit that odour

> “The room smells of coffee.”

= 房間有咖啡味。

Very high-value grammar contrast.

Important distinction: ****smell like vs smell of****

****smell like X****

= 氣味像 X

****smell of X****

= 散發 X 的氣味

Often overlap:

> “It smells like coffee.”

> = 聞起來像咖啡。

> “It smells of coffee.”

> = 有咖啡味。

****Like**** emphasizes similarity; ****of**** emphasizes source/character.

Important distinction: ****smell good vs good smell****

****smell good****

verb + adjective:

> 聞起來很香 / 很好聞

****a good smell****

noun phrase:

> 好聞的氣味

Grammar differs.

Important distinction: **smelly vs fragrant**

smelly

= unpleasant-smelling

fragrant

= pleasantly scented

> smelly socks

> = 臭襪子

> fragrant bread/herbs

> = 香氣撲鼻的麵包 / 香草

Opposite connotations.

Important distinction: **smell — literal vs figurative**

Literal

> “I smell smoke.”

= 我聞到煙味。

Figurative

> “I smell trouble.”

= 我感覺到要有麻煩。

Same underlying concept:

> detect something before it becomes obvious.

Important distinction: **smell of corruption vs smell corruption**

smell corruption

= figuratively detect corruption.

smell of corruption

= something seems to carry signs/suspicion of corruption.

Both are figurative, but grammar differs.

Important grammar note: **smell is a linking verb**

Like:

- * look
- * sound
- * feel
- * taste

it can take an adjective:

- > smell good 
- > smell strange 

Not normally:

- > *smell well* 

unless **well** means “with a good sense of smell” in a different structure, e.g.

- > “Dogs smell well” is possible but uncommon/awkward.

For describing the odour:

- > **smells good**

is the natural form.

Important grammar note: **smelled / smelt**

Both are correct past forms.

AmE:

- > smelled

BrE:

> smelled / smelt

Examples:

> “I smelled smoke.”

> “I smelt smoke.”

Both:

「我聞到煙味。」

For consistency in international learner English, ****smelled**** is the safest default.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern family includes:

- * ****smell — noun: odour**** = 氣味 / 香味
- * ****bad smell**** = 臭味 / 難聞氣味
- * ****sense of smell**** = 嗅覺
- * ****smell + object**** = 聞到 / 嗅到
- * ****smell + adjective**** = 聞起來.....
- * ****smell of**** = 有.....氣味
- * ****smell like**** = 聞起來像.....
- * ****smell something deliberately**** = 聞一聞 / 嗅一嗅
- * ****smell — emit bad odour**** = 發臭
- * ****smell trouble/danger**** = 察覺麻煩 / 危險
- * ****smell a rat**** = 懷疑有問題
- * ****smell of + abstract noun**** = 帶有.....嫌疑 / 意味
- * ****smelly**** = 有臭味的
- * ****smelled / smelt**** = 過去式 / 過去分詞

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
smell — noun	鼻子可以感受到的某種氣味
bad smell	令人不舒服的臭味 / 難聞氣味
sense of smell	用鼻子辨認氣味的感官能力
smell + object	透過嗅覺察覺某種氣味
smell + adjective	某物散發出的氣味呈現某種特質；聞起來.....

smell of X	散發出 X 的氣味	
smell like X	氣味與 X 相似	
smell deliberately	主動把某物靠近鼻子辨認氣味	
smell — bad odour	本身散發出難聞氣味；發臭	
smell — figurative	憑直覺察覺危險、麻煩或異常	
smell a rat	覺得事情不對勁，懷疑有人欺騙 / 隱瞞	
smell of + abstract noun	令人感覺帶有某種負面性質、嫌疑或意味	
smelly	散發明顯難聞氣味的	

For your original sentence

> “To be honest, what caught my attention first was not the signboard, but the **smell**.”

The exact meaning is:

**smell = 從麵包店飄出來、可以用鼻子感受到的氣味；由於下一句說是 freshly baked bread 的 aroma，所以這裡具體是「新鮮烘焙麵包的香味」。

Natural translation:

> **「老實說，最先吸引我注意的不是招牌，而是那股香味。」

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > **a pleasant smell** → 好聞的氣味
- > **a bad smell** → 臭味
- > **sense of smell** → 嗅覺
- > **smell bread** → 聞到麵包香
- > **smell good** → 聞起來很香
- > **smell of coffee** → 有咖啡味
- > **smell like coffee** → 聞起來像咖啡
- > **smell trouble** → 察覺麻煩
- > **smell a rat** → 懷疑有問題
- > **smelly** → 有臭味的